

The twists and turns that have shaped Linux warrant a separate book, but here we present what we think are the key points in the evolution of Linux.

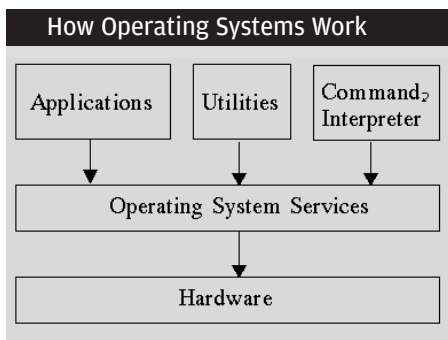
OK, so you already know Linux is an OS—that's a good starting point. Operating systems are almost as old as computers themselves. You see, one can't quite live without the other. Simply put, the OS is like the engine for a car: it is what makes everything else run.

1.1.1 The operating system

Think of any device—not just a computer—on which applications can be installed: there has to be an OS. For example, your mobile handheld that allows you to download and install applications has an OS.

The concept of the operating system came about during the 1950s and 60s. This was the time when tremendous progress happened in the field of computing (or for that matter, in most fields. Remember, this was the time when the world was rebuilding itself after the two world wars, and science and technology saw peaceable applications). Computers at that time were used only in research institutes, universities, and large banks. (But the tasks these computers did were a lot simpler than what is being thrown at our monster machines now!) As greater performance was expected off computers, better hardware and OSes came to be created and used.

In this period, there was a shift from batch processing to the time sharing method of computing. This simply meant that



A schematic representation of the way an operating system functions